On this particular day, like any other, the Yatra commenced punctually from Phillaur, Jalandhar, Punjab. Local Congress leaders from the Jalandhar constituency arrived one by one to meet Rahul Gandhi. The Jalandhar MP, Santosh Singh Chaudhary, positioned to Rahul's right, graciously moved to the left to introduce them. Known for his gentle demeanour, the MP rarely raised his voice, always wearing a smile on his face. As he approached Rahul, I affectionately placed my hand on his shoulder and greeted him as 'Bhaiya'.

'How are you, Jothi?' he said, with the same smile on his gentle face. Suddenly, in the blink of an eye, he collapsed. Shocked, I attempted to support him, urgently calling out to Alankar Sawai (Rahul Gandhi's aide, who accompanied him throughout the Yatra) for assistance. By then, the MP seemed to be leaning over, and Alankar rushed over to provide first aid. The MP's son, who was in the front row, hurried to the scene. In the middle of the chaos, I called for an ambulance, bringing the Yatra to a halt, with Rahul also arriving. Even as the ambulance began its journey carrying him, the tension lingered. Rahul, concerned, asked, 'What happened, Jothi?' I was frozen in shock, my body trembling, and I stammered, 'I don't know if there is life in him.' My mind was equally shaken.

A perturbed Rahul, upon spotting Punjab PCC President Raja Warring, immediately asked him to rush to the hospital and check on him. Upon our arrival, the sight of his wife embracing his lifeless body, pleading, 'Do something. He is still warm,' was heart-wrenching. A bystander mentioned that I was the last person he spoke to, and the grieving wife's eyes turned towards me. Attempting to console her, I hugged her, but words failed me. Her body trembled as she returned to her husband, caressing his face, his radiant expression giving no indication of death. Tearfully, she softly asked, 'What were his last words, my daughter?' I recounted the events, my voice trembling.

As we left the hospital, the march was cancelled and we headed to our lodging. Shock had frozen my mind, and my body trembled. Witnessing death from such proximity weighed heavy.